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Bui_Tran_Quoc_Anh_Proposal

Course 66

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International Academic Research Competition 2026

Research Proposal

Investigating the Role of Vietnamese Traditional Dry Puppetry (*Rối Cạn*) as Play-Based Emotional Regulation: A Case Study Among Flood-Surviving Ethnic Minority Children in Vietnam

Author

Bui Tran Quoc Anh

Affiliation

Hanoi – Amsterdam High School for the Gifted

Submission Date

09/20/2026

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1. INTRODUCTION & PROBLEM CONTEXT

1.1. Context & Severity of the Problem

In September 2024, Northern Vietnam was severely impacted by Typhoon Yagi, resulting in catastrophic flooding. Aside from thousands of homes being submerged, there was a severe breakdown in children's ecosystem [1]. Schools were completely shut down for consecutive months while primary caregivers were grappling with economic difficulties and making a livelihood. Children residing in these disaster zones consequently lacked both parental care and interaction with their peers [1], [2]. Moreover, aside from residing in temporary shelters, these children also experienced severe trauma from witnessing the destruction of their homes, schools, and potentially the loss of their relatives. Recent syntheses across Southeast Asia indicate that pediatric post-traumatic stress disorder (PTSD) was between 21.16% and 29.36% following catastrophic typhoons, escalating up to 46.5% among cohorts in temporary camps [3]. In mountainous areas, this disruption is compounded by school shutdowns and the lack of parental care, damaging children's ecological microsystem. Without early and proper intervention, children would likely suffer from irreversible distress in the later part of their lives [4].

1.2. Research Topic & Rationale

16 Conventional Western psychological interventions, such as Trauma-Focused Cognitive Behavioral Therapy (TF-CBT), frequently encounter language, cultural, and cognitive barriers when applied to indigenous or ethnic minority children (e.g., the *Tày* ethnic group) [5]. Furthermore, while traditional Vietnamese Water Puppetry is culturally significant, its liquid visual elements carry a high risk of triggering traumatization for flood survivors. Consequently, this proposal introduces Vietnamese Traditional Dry Puppetry (*Rối Cạn*), which resonates profoundly with the minorities' tradition in Northern Vietnam. Unlike other therapies, Dry Puppetry can be made from localized materials, enabling low-cost, rapid execution within temporary shelters. This land-based intervention provides a culturally congruent, non-verbal, and sensory-rich framework specifically tailored for disaster-exposed indigenous children. Formally recognized as National Intangible Cultural Heritage [6], the centuries-old *Tày* rod puppetry incorporates traditional *phách* percussive cadences and *Nôm-Tày* chants to restore communal harmony after environmental adversities [6]–[8]. In contrast to water puppetry, which acts as a trigger for flood-induced panic, the smooth, organic touch of rod puppetry provides soothing sensory anchors that facilitate calmness and affection in children [9], [10].

2. RESEARCH QUESTIONS & OBJECTIVES

The primary objective is to develop, evaluate, and scale a culturally familiar, land-based dry puppetry intervention designed to alleviate post-traumatic stress and foster emotional regulation among flood-impacted children.

Primary Research Question (Primary RQ):

In what aspects and to what extent does Vietnamese Traditional Dry Puppetry (*Rối Cạn*) alleviate flood-induced post-traumatic stress and enhance emotional regulation among ethnic minority children?

Sub-Research Questions (Sub-RQs):

1. Which specific dimensions of post-traumatic stress (e.g., anxiety, selective mutism) and emotional regulation are significantly impacted by the puppetry intervention?

2. To what extent does structured dry puppetry outperform unstructured recreational activities in reducing psychological trauma?

3. Is it feasible to implement and execute therapeutic dry puppetry sessions effectively without certified psychiatric specialists (e.g., facilitated by trained local educators)?

4. How do qualitative somatic and behavioral observations during dry puppetry correlate with standardized reductions in pediatric post-traumatic stress severity?

3. LITERATURE REVIEW & THEORETICAL FRAMEWORK

3.1. Existing Literature and Knowledge Gap

Extant literature on pediatric disaster psychology strongly supports the efficacy of play therapy in trauma recovery [11]. However, established clinical methodologies predominantly rely on Western paradigms. There remains a critical knowledge gap regarding the integration of culturally adapted, indigenous art-based therapies in non-Western, low-resource settings. This study addresses this gap by operationalizing and empirically evaluating *Rối Cạn* as a viable, scalable trauma intervention.

3.2. Theoretical Framework

The proposed intervention is anchored in three foundational theoretical pillars:

• **Play Therapy Theory & Aesthetic Distancing:** Puppetry acts as an external container for projection. By establishing psychological distance between the child and their trauma, children can safely process traumatic memories without direct psychological re-exposure [9], [10].

• **Adaptive Information Processing (AIP) Model:** This clinical model posits that traumatic memories encoded during somatic sensory overload can be cognitively re-processed and integrated through structured, symbolic storytelling and guided play [12].

• **Bottom-Up Somatic Regulation:** Drawing from neurobiology, this approach utilizes non-verbal bodily movements, rhythm, tactile puppet handling, and breathing exercises to regulate the autonomic nervous system prior to addressing higher-level cognitive processing [13], [14].

4. PROPOSED METHODOLOGY

4.1. Study Design and Sampling Strategy

This study will employ a quasi-experimental pre-test/post-test control group design. The target population consists of disaster-exposed *Tày* ethnic minority children (aged 6–12) residing in flood-affected evacuation centers. Using purposive and cluster sampling, a sample size of N = 60 will be recruited. Participants will be assigned to either the Intervention Group (receiving the Dry Puppetry sessions) or the Control Group (receiving standard unstructured recreational activities).

4.2. Intervention Design & Measurement Tools

The intervention utilizes interactive peer dialogue between two puppet characters who portray flood survival. Children project their internal fears onto the puppets and practice somatic expressions (e.g., deep breathing techniques, physical self-soothing) to co-regulate their nervous systems.

TABLE I: OPERATIONALIZATION OF VARIABLES AND CLINICAL MEASUREMENT TOOLS

Variable Type	Construct	Measurement Tool
Independent	Puppetry Intervention	Intervention Fidelity Checklist
Dependent (Primary)	PTSD Symptom Severity	Child PTSD Symptom Scale (CPSS-5) [15]
Dependent (Secondary)	Emotional Regulation	Emotion Regulation Checklist (ERC) [16]

4.3. Data Analysis

Quantitative data will be analyzed using Paired t-tests (to assess within-group pre/post changes) and Analysis of Covariance (ANCOVA) to compare between-group differences while controlling for pre-existing trauma baseline, age, and extent of disaster loss. Qualitative data, sourced from behavioral observation logs, will undergo thematic analysis to map the somatic and emotional expressions of the participants.

4.4. Study Procedure and Timeline

- **Baseline Assessment (T0):** Following communal clearances, bilingual evaluators administer culturally adapted, *Tày*-translated visual and verbal screening batteries (CPSS-5, caregiver-report ERC) across enrolled participants (N = 60) to establish pre-intervention clinical profiles.

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- **Intervention Execution:** Over a structured 6-week timeframe, the active arm receives 12 bi-weekly, 60-minute *Rối Cạn* sessions integrating *phách* percussive attunement, bilateral puppet manipulation, and restorative narrative projection (1:5 facilitator-to-child ratio); the control arm participates in parallel-frequency unstructured recreational activities.
- **Post-Activity Data Collection (T1):** Immediately post-intervention, independent evaluators masked to study arms repeat the psychometric battery to capture immediate shifts in trauma symptom severity and affective regulation.
- **Follow-Up Evaluation (T2):** At 6 weeks post-intervention, longitudinal assessments and semi-structured child-caregiver interviews evaluate symptom retention, behavioral stability, and community intervention acceptability.

4.5. Ethical Considerations & Child Protection

Prior to data collection, institutional ethics approval will be secured in accordance with the Declaration of Helsinki. Informed parental/guardian consent and child assent will be obtained using culturally and linguistically adapted bilingual (Vietnamese–*Tày*) documentation. An adverse-event safety protocol will be established, guaranteeing immediate referral to regional clinical mental health professionals should any participant experience acute psychological distress. All clinical screening data will be fully de-identified and secured.

Expected Contributions & Significance

Academically, this research expands the global literature on indigenous play therapy by establishing rigorous empirical evidence for Vietnamese traditional dry puppetry, thereby advancing non-verbal trauma recovery frameworks for non-Western populations. Practically, it yields a highly portable, low-cost psychological first-aid toolkit that empowers local educators and volunteers to deliver immediate, community-based trauma alleviation without relying on permanent psychiatric infrastructure.

Potential Limitations

Methodological constraints include a quasi-experimental cluster design necessitated by evacuation shelter logistics, precluding individual randomization and risking shared-living contamination. Furthermore, localized *Tày* cultural and dialectical tailoring limits immediate psychometric generalizability to non-highland ethnic populations without iterative regional adaptation.

Project Practicalities

Operational execution within mountainous evacuation camps relies on mobile delivery units and localized fabrication. Puppets are carved on-site from native *thừng mực* timber, bamboo, and remnant textiles ($18.50 per-child unit cost). Sessions are delivered by local educators maintaining a 1:5 facilitator-to-child ratio.

Post-Program Plan

Following project completion, standardized physical puppet kits, bilingual facilitation toolkits, and open-access micro-training videos will be permanently transferred to commune boarding schools and the Ho Chi Minh Communist Youth Union. Curricula will be disseminated to regional disaster management task forces.

Conclusion

This investigation positions Vietnamese dry puppetry not as a universal clinical panacea, but as an indigenous, scalable psychological first-aid blueprint. Transforming traditional folk arts into somatic healing tools advances global disaster psychiatry beyond imported Western templates toward culturally organic community recovery.

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APPENDICES

Appendix A: Clinical Measurement Tools Overview

Caption: Summary of the primary assessment tool utilized for quantifying trauma symptomology.

The Child PTSD Symptom Scale (CPSS-5) will be translated, culturally adapted, and validated for the *Tày* dialect [15]. It systematically assesses DSM-5 PTSD criteria, including intrusion, avoidance, negative alterations in cognition and mood, and alterations in arousal and reactivity. This ensures that the qualitative distress expressed during play is correlated with standardized psychiatric metrics.

Appendix B: Dry Puppetry Somatic Interaction Script (Excerpt)

Caption: A sample therapeutic dialogue designed to facilitate bottom-up somatic regulation.

Puppet A (Voi - The Elephant):

- "When the big rain came, my heart was beating like a fast drum. Thump-thump-thump! I couldn't speak."

Puppet B (Rua - The Turtle):

- "I was scared too. I hid in my shell. What did you do to make the fast drum stop?"

Puppet A:

- "I put my trunk on my chest, and I took a long breath in... and blew out slowly. Let's practice together with our friends here!"

(Facilitator prompts the participants to mimic the deep breathing exercise alongside the puppets, actively applying somatic regulation techniques before cognitive processing begins).

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